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Submitted To



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This report discusses three uniquely relevant Economic ideas from the ancient world that remain applicable today, justifying their modern significance through contemporary examples.

Greek Economic Thought

Plato and Aristotle's economic ideas still show their significance today, especially in places like Bangladesh. Plato believed that dividing work based on what people are good at was key to economic success. This can be seen in Bangladesh's ready-made garments (RMG) industry, where workers focus on specific tasks. This specialization has helped the country become a leader in garment production, creating jobs and boosting the economy. It shows that Plato's emphasis on focusing on strengths and specialization still plays a big role in making modern industries more efficient.

On the other hand, Aristotle opposed charging interest, which he considered unnatural. This philosophy is also reflected in Bangladesh's Islamic banking system, where interest is replaced by profit-sharing. Islamic banks in Bangladesh promote financial transactions without interest, demonstrating one of Aristotle's beliefs in ethical money practices. Take Grameen Bank as an example. It gives small loans to entrepreneurs without charging them high-interest rates, focusing on a fairer distribution of wealth. This idea aligns with Aristotle's view that social welfare should come before just making a profit.

But even though these ancient economic ideas still resonate today, how relevant they are depends on how they adapt to modern challenges. For instance, Plato's division of labor has definitely helped Bangladesh's garment industry grow, but it has also brought up concerns about worker exploitation and poor conditions. Similarly, Aristotle's stance against charging interest fits with Islamic finance principles, but limiting interest-based loans can sometimes hold back financial growth and innovation.

Buddhist Economic Thought

Buddhist economic principles like moderation, thrift, and using wealth for the good of others are still very relevant in today's corporate world. The idea that surplus wealth should be used to help others aligns with corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives. Many companies now actively support causes like education, healthcare, and poverty alleviation, showing that it is possible to balance making profits with making a positive impact on society.

Buddha's teachings about the ethical use of wealth are especially important for responsible business practices. In an economy, the government may encourage CSR policies that push companies to invest in social welfare programs. This commitment highlights not just the goal of economic growth but also the ethical distribution of wealth, which is a key part of Buddhist economics. It is evident to see how modern CSR practices are influenced by these ancient ideas, fostering a culture of social responsibility stakeholders of the business.

However, this may lead to some conflicts: while Buddhist economics promotes using wealth, to help others, many modern businesses focus primarily on maximizing profits. This shift can create a gap, as Buddhist teachings emphasize that wealth should not just be for personal gain but should also be used

to better society. Nowadays, many firms participate in CSR, and while it may appear as they are embracing Buddhist ideals, their true motivations can sometimes be less than sincere.

In many cases, businesses may engage in CSR more as a strategy to enhance their public image, build customer loyalty, or avoid negative publicity. This means that the contributions they make to social causes might be more about marketing than a genuine concern for society's welfare. For example, a company might donate to a charity not because they care about the cause, but to enhance their reputation and boost their brand. This highlights how the drive for profit can clash with the ethical ideals of using wealth for the greater good, as emphasized in Buddhist economics.

Chinese Economic Thought

Confucian economic thought, particularly Mencius's idea of benevolent governance and light taxation, finds relevance in modern tax policies, especially in countries like the U.S. The progressive tax system, where the wealthy contribute a higher percentage of their income to taxes, is in line with Confucian principles that emphasize the moral duty of the state to protect the well-being of its citizens. President Biden's proposals to increase taxes on the ultra-wealthy and provide relief for lower-income households reflect the Confucian ideal of promoting social harmony and reducing inequality through taxation.

Additionally, Confucianism's advocacy for limited government intervention in markets aligns with the U.S.'s capitalist structure. While the government generally refrains from heavy market regulation, moments of crisis, such as the COVID-19 pandemic, saw interventions like stimulus checks and unemployment benefits. This reflects Confucian ideas of "benevolent governance," where the state steps in to support its citizens during times of hardship. Confucian thought on governance is thus still relevant in modern economic policymaking, especially when balancing free markets with the need for state intervention during crises.

However, in today's globalized world, where countries are connected through trade and international competition, sticking to these principles is not always easy. Governments have to balance fairness in taxation with the demands of a free market economy, where businesses and individuals expect fewer restrictions and lower taxes to encourage growth. In this system, if taxes are too high, some believe it might discourage investment and slow down the economy.

At the same time, it is debatable whether the current tax system is truly fair. Some people argue that the rich still do not pay enough, while others think that the tax burden on businesses and individuals is already too high. This shows that the Confucian idea of using taxes to promote the well-being of all people is still relevant, but how it is applied today is complex. Governments may need to adapt these ancient ideas to modern economic contexts, finding the right balance between fairness and economic growth.